A FREE, PLAIN-SPOKEN GUIDE



# Is That Really Their Voice?

## Spotting AI Voice-Clone Scams and Deepfake Calls, and Protecting Your Family

Family code words • Call-back habits
Deepfake video calls • Protecting your voice

D.A. Williams

# Is That Really Their Voice?

## Spotting AI Voice-Clone Scams and Deepfake Calls, and Protecting Your Family

**D.A. Williams**

Published by Red Pills of Freedom

Free to share. Please pass it on to someone who needs it.

*Dedicated to Mom, Janis Fredlund*

**Free to share. Please pass it on to someone who needs it.**

Copyright © 2026 D.A. Williams.

Published by Red Pills of Freedom.

You may copy, print, email, post, and share this book, in whole or in part, free of charge for any non-commercial purpose, as long as you keep the author's name and this notice with it and do not change the text. You may not sell it or include it in anything that is sold. For any other use, please contact the author.

First edition, October 2026.

This book is for general education. It is not legal advice. Facts and figures were checked against the sources listed in the Notes at the back of the book as of October 2026. Technology changes fast. If something looks different when you try it, check the official website named in the book.

The short scenes marked "Example" in this book are made up to show how a scam usually works. They are not stories about real people.

# Contents

INTRODUCTION
When You Can't Trust Your Own Ears ..... 5

CHAPTER 1
What Voice Clones and Deepfakes Really Are ..... 8

CHAPTER 2
How Voice-Clone Scams Work ..... 11

CHAPTER 3
The Family Code Word ..... 15

CHAPTER 4
Verification Habits That Beat Any Fake ..... 18

CHAPTER 5
Deepfake Video Calls ..... 21

CHAPTER 6
Fake Celebrities, Fake Bosses, Fake Officials ..... 24

CHAPTER 7
Myths About AI Fakes, and the Truth ..... 27

CHAPTER 8
Protecting Your Own Voice and Face ..... 31

CHAPTER 9
If You Get One of These Calls ..... 35

CHAPTER 10
Talking About It with Kids, Teens, and Older Relatives ..... 38

APPENDIX
The One-Page "Is That Really Them?" Checklist ..... 40

RESOURCES
Where to Get Help ..... 41

Notes ..... 43

INTRODUCTION

# When You Can't Trust Your Own Ears

For all of human history, a familiar voice meant a familiar person. If your daughter called crying, it was your daughter. If your boss called with an urgent request, it was your boss.

That's no longer a safe bet.

Computer programs can now copy a person's voice. The Federal Trade Commission (FTC) warned in 2023 that a scammer only needs "a short audio clip of your family member's voice — which he could get from content posted online — and a voice-cloning program." When the scammer calls, "he'll sound just like your loved one."[1]

The FBI says criminals are using these tools to make fake voices, fake photos, and even fake live video for real-time chats.[2] In 2025, the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) received more than 22,000 complaints that mentioned artificial intelligence (AI), with reported losses of more than $893 million.[3]

This book will not teach you to become a detective who can spot every fake. Honestly, nobody can. The FBI itself says AI-generated content "has advanced to the point that it is often difficult to identify."[4] Instead, this book teaches something better: **simple habits that protect you even when the fake is perfect.**

## What's inside

- **Chapter 1** explains, in plain words, what voice cloning and deepfakes are.
- **Chapter 2** walks through the most common scams that use them.
- **Chapters 3 and 4** are the heart of the book: the family code word and the verification habits that beat any fake.
- **Chapter 5** covers deepfake video calls.
- **Chapter 6** covers fake celebrities, fake bosses, and fake officials.
- **Chapter 7** clears up common myths about AI fakes.
- **Chapter 8** shows how to protect your own voice and image.
- **Chapter 9** tells you exactly what to do if you get one of these calls, or if you already paid.
- **Chapter 10** helps you talk about all this with family.

At the back, there's a one-page checklist to print, a list of free help, and Notes with sources for every fact.

This book is part of a series. *Protect Your Parents* covers phone and text scams against older adults, and *After a Scam* covers recovery if money is already gone.

CHAPTER 1

# What Voice Clones and Deepfakes Really Are

You don't need to understand the technology to protect yourself. But a little understanding takes away some of the fear.

## Voice cloning

A **voice clone** is a computer-made copy of a real person's voice. You give a program a recording of someone talking, and it learns how they sound. Then you can type any words, and the program "says" them in that person's voice.

Voice cloning has real, honest uses: narrating books, dubbing movies, and helping people who are losing their ability to speak. Consumer Reports notes these legitimate uses. But it also found that many voice-cloning products make it easy to clone someone without their permission. In a March 2025 assessment of six voice-cloning products, Consumer Reports researchers were able to easily create a clone from publicly available audio in four of them. Those four only asked the user to check a box saying they had the right to clone the voice.[5]

## Deepfakes

A **deepfake** is fake video, audio, or images made or changed with AI to look and sound real. A deepfake might show someone's face saying words they never said, or put one person's face on another person's body.

The FBI lists the ways criminals use these tools:[2]

- **Fake audio:** short clips of a loved one's voice in a crisis, asking for money or demanding a ransom. The FBI also says criminals use AI-generated audio of people to try to get into their bank accounts.
- **Fake images:** realistic profile photos, fake ID cards, fake badges, and fake pictures to "prove" they're a real person.
- **Fake video:** video for real-time video chats with fake company executives, police, or other authority figures, and fake promotional videos for investment schemes.

## Why this matters now

Two things changed: the tools got better, and they got easier. The FBI's 2025 report says AI-made content is "becoming increasingly difficult to detect and easier to make."[3] You no longer need to be a computer expert to make a convincing fake.

## The good news

Every scam in this book still needs one thing from you: **action.** Sending money, sharing a code, clicking a link, giving information. A fake voice can't take money out of your account by itself. If you build the habit of checking before you act, the fake loses most of its power.

CHAPTER 2

# How Voice-Clone Scams Work

Most AI voice scams are old scams in new clothes. The story is the same; only the voice is more convincing.

## The family emergency (“distress”) call

This is the most common one. Someone calls sounding exactly like your child, grandchild, spouse, or friend. They’re crying, panicked, or whispering. They’ve been in an accident, arrested, or are stranded. They need money right now, and please don’t tell anyone.

> *Example (made up to show how it works): Linda’s phone rings. It’s her son’s voice, shaky: “Mom, I hit someone with the car. They’re saying I’m going to jail. I need you to help me.” A second man comes on, calm and official, and explains how to send bail money today. The voice sounded so much like her son that Linda’s hands were shaking.*

The FBI’s 2025 report says victims reported losing more than $5 million to these “distress” scams in 2025. It adds

that the scam "is evolving to mimic other family members or close friends in different types of emergency scenarios."[3] That number is surely low: many people never report, and many don't realize AI was involved.

## The "virtual kidnapping" call or text

In December 2025, the FBI warned about criminals who claim they've kidnapped a loved one and demand ransom. They often threaten violence if you don't pay immediately. Then they send what looks like a real photo or video of your loved one as "proof of life." The FBI says these are often altered from photos found on social media. On close inspection, they may have mistakes, like missing tattoos or scars, or body proportions that are off. Some criminals send them with disappearing-message features so you don't have time to look closely.[6]

The FBI's advice: always try to contact your loved one before considering any ransom; stop and think about whether the claims make sense; screenshot or record the "proof"; and use a family code word.[6]

## The fake boss or coworker

At work, scammers use cloned voices or fake video of executives to request urgent wire transfers or gift cards. The FBI's 2025 report says businesses reported losses of more than $30 million to business email compromise scams involving AI, and notes that voice cloning can be used to request wire payments.[3] Chapter 5 tells the story

of a company that lost about $25 million after a deepfake video meeting.

## The fake official

Since April 2025, the FBI has warned about text and AI-generated voice messages pretending to come from senior U.S. officials. The goal is to build trust, then get people to click a link or move to another messaging app, which can lead to stolen accounts.[4]

## The fake bank call

The FBI says criminals have used AI-generated audio clips of people to get into their bank accounts.[2] Scammers also pretend to *be* the bank, as they always have. A real bank, the FTC says, will never contact you to tell you to transfer money or to ask for your passcodes.[7]

## What all of these have in common

Look at every story above. Each one has:

1. **A voice or face you trust.**
2. **An emergency.**
3. **A rush.**
4. **A demand for secrecy.**
5. **A request for money, a code, or a click.**

The voice is new. Everything else is the same old scam. And that's why the defenses in the next two chapters work.

CHAPTER 3

# The Family Code Word

If you do only one thing after reading this book, do this.

A **family code word** (or code phrase) is a secret that only your family knows. If someone calls in an emergency asking for money, you ask for the code word. A real family member will know it. A scammer with a perfect copy of their voice won't.

The FBI recommends this directly: "Create a secret word or phrase with your family to verify their identity."[2] The FBI repeated the advice in its 2025 warnings about virtual kidnapping and impersonation of officials,[6,4] and the FBI and American Bankers Association Foundation included it in their 2025 deepfake infographic.[8]

## How to set one up

1. **Pick something memorable but not public.** Avoid pet names, street names, schools, birthdays, or anything on social media. A silly phrase works well: "purple pancakes," "Uncle Ray's boat." (Don't use these examples; make your own.)

2. **Share it in person** or on a call *you* started. Don't put it in a group chat, email, or social media post.
3. **Agree on the rule.** For example: "If anyone in this family calls asking for money in an emergency, they must say the code word. No word, no money, no matter what."
4. **Include everyone who might get or make a call:** parents, grandparents, adult children, teens.
5. **Practice once.** Make a pretend call. It feels silly, but it makes the habit stick.
6. **Change it if it leaks.** If you think someone outside the family learned it, pick a new one.

## Some helpful variations

- **A question-and-answer pair.** One person asks "Did you feed the goldfish?" and the right answer is something unexpected, like "We don't have a goldfish." This is harder to guess.
- **A "duress" word.** Some families add a second word that means "I'm really in trouble and can't talk freely." (This is optional and only helpful if everyone remembers it.)
- **A work version.** Businesses can set up a verification step for any request to move money, so no one ever has to rely on recognizing a voice.

## What if they don't know the word?

Then hang up and call your loved one directly on the number you already have. If they don't answer, call another family member. Don't send money until you've confirmed, no matter how real the voice sounds.

## What a code word can't do

A code word is not magic. A real family member in a real panic might forget it. That's okay: the rule is still "hang up and verify." The code word is a quick test. The call-back (Chapter 4) is the real safety net.

CHAPTER 4

# Verification Habits That Beat Any Fake

Here's the most important idea in this book:

> **THE MOST IMPORTANT THING IN THIS BOOK:** Don't try to judge whether a voice or video is real. Instead, verify the *request* through a different channel you already trust. A perfect fake can't survive a call-back.

## Habit 1: Hang up and call back

If someone calls asking for money, information, or urgent action, **hang up and call them back using a number you already have.** Not the number on caller ID. Not a number they give you.

The FTC's advice for voice clones: "Don't trust the voice. Call the person who supposedly contacted you and verify the story. Use a phone number you know is theirs."[1] The FBI gives the same advice for calls claiming to be from a bank or organization: hang up, look up the contact information yourself, and call directly.[2]

## Habit 2: Use a second channel

If a “family member” calls from a new number, text or call their usual number. If your “boss” emails or calls asking for a wire transfer, walk to their office, or call their known number. The FBI says that if someone you know contacts you on a new platform or phone number, verify it through “a previously confirmed platform or trusted source.”[4]

## Habit 3: Slow down on purpose

Every one of these scams depends on rushing you. The FBI and ABA Foundation’s first tip is to “stop and think before responding to urgent or emotional requests.”[8]

Give yourself permission to say: **“I’m going to call you right back.”** A real emergency can survive a two-minute check. A scam usually can’t.

## Habit 4: Ask a question only they would know

Ask something that isn’t on social media. “What did we have for dinner last Sunday?” “What’s the name of the neighbor’s dog?” This isn’t foolproof (scammers can be clever, and a stressed person may not remember), but it often trips them up.

## Habit 5: Never pay the way a scammer asks

Scammers ask for payments that are hard to reverse: gift cards, wire transfers, cryptocurrency, and payment apps. The FTC says that if the caller asks you to wire money, send cryptocurrency, or buy gift cards and give them the numbers, "those could be signs of a scam."[1] The FBI says not to send money, gift cards, cryptocurrency, or other assets to people you know only online or over the phone.[2]

## Habit 6: Never share codes

Never read back a one-time login code to anyone who calls you, even if they sound like your bank or a family member. The FBI warns that scammers use tricks to get people to give up two-factor authentication codes so they can take over accounts.[4]

## Habit 7: Listen, but don't rely on your ears

The FBI suggests listening closely to "the tone and word choice" for clues that a voice is cloned.[2] The FBI and ABA Foundation list "flat or robotic voice tones" as one sign.[8] Notice those things, but don't rely on them. The FBI also says cloned voices and real ones "can sound nearly identical."[4] If something feels off, that's a reason to verify. If nothing feels off, that's *not* proof it's real.

CHAPTER 5

# Deepfake Video Calls

Many people think, “If I can see them on video, it must be real.” That used to be a good rule. It isn’t anymore.

## The $25 million video meeting

In early 2024, police in Hong Kong described a case in which a finance worker at a multinational company joined a video call with people he believed were the company’s chief financial officer and other coworkers. All of them, police said, were deepfake re-creations. In May 2024, the British engineering firm Arup confirmed to CNN that it was the company involved and that “fake voices and images were used.”[9]

According to CNN’s reporting, the worker had first suspected the request was a phishing email, because it asked for a secret transaction. But he put his doubts aside after the video call, because the people looked and sounded like colleagues he knew. He sent a total of 200 million Hong Kong dollars, about $25.6 million, in 15 transactions.[9]

Notice what almost saved him: his first instinct that a *secret* money transfer was suspicious. Notice what would have saved him: calling the real CFO on a known number before sending a penny.

## Fake video in personal scams

The FBI says criminals create videos to "prove" an online contact is a real person, and use AI-generated video in real-time video chats.[2] Romance scammers, fake investment "advisors," and fake officials can all use this.

## Signs a video might be fake

The FBI and ABA Foundation list these signs of deepfake media:[8]

- Blurry or distorted facial features
- Unnatural blinking or facial movements
- Audio that doesn't match the video
- Flat or robotic voice tones
- Odd lighting or shadows

The FBI adds: distorted hands, unrealistic teeth or eyes, odd glasses or jewelry, inaccurate shadows, watermarks, lag, and unnatural movements.[2] The FBI's 2025 report also describes fake job interviews where lip movements didn't line up with the audio, and coughs or sneezes didn't match what was on screen.[3]

**But remember:** these are clues, not proof. Good fakes may show none of them.

## Simple tests you can try on a live call

These are common-sense checks, not guarantees. Better fakes may pass them:

- Ask the person to turn their head fully to the side, or wave a hand slowly in front of their face.
- Ask them to say your name and today's date.
- Ask about something only the real person would know.
- Say you'll call them back, then hang up and call on a number you know.

The last one is the only test that really counts.

## What to do

1. **If a video call includes a request for money, codes, or secrecy,** treat it exactly like a phone call: hang up and verify through a known channel.
2. **At work,** insist on a call-back to a known number for any payment request, no matter who appears on screen.
3. **Never let a video call rush you.** "I'll call you right back" is always an acceptable answer.

CHAPTER 6

# Fake Celebrities, Fake Bosses, Fake Officials

AI doesn't only fake family members. It also fakes famous and powerful people.

## Fake celebrity and expert endorsements

The FBI's 2025 report says investment scammers use "AI-generated videos and voices of celebrities, CEOs, or trusted figures" to create fake investment opportunities, often with professional-looking endorsements on social media or in video calls. Losses in investment complaints with a reported AI connection topped $632 million in 2025. The FBI adds that overall investment scam losses exceeded $8 billion, "demonstrating that many victims do not realize the extent AI may be involved."[3]

Consumer Reports also notes that scammers have used voice cloning to make celebrities and political figures appear to endorse dubious products and bogus investment schemes.[5]

**What to do:** Treat any video of a famous person promoting an investment, a giveaway, or a "secret"

money-making method as an ad, not a recommendation. Look up the company yourself. Never send money or crypto because of a video.

## Fake bosses and coworkers

Businesses are a big target because one fake approval can move a lot of money. The defense is a written rule: **no money moves on a phone call, voice message, or video call alone.** Every request gets verified by a call-back to a known number, or a second person signs off.

## Fake government officials

The FBI warned in 2025 that criminals were sending AI-generated voice messages pretending to be senior U.S. officials.[4] Social Security also warns about government impostors who send official-looking documents and use the real names of government employees.[10]

**What to do:** If a message claims to be from a government official, don't reply to it or click its links. Look up the agency's contact information yourself.

## Robocalls with AI voices are illegal

In February 2024, the Federal Communications Commission (FCC) unanimously ruled that calls made with AI-generated voices count as "artificial" voices under the Telephone Consumer Protection Act, the federal robocall law.[11] In plain terms, the robocall rules

that apply to recorded voices also apply to AI voices. That doesn't stop criminals from making illegal calls, but you can report them to the FCC and the FTC.

CHAPTER 7

# Myths About AI Fakes, and the Truth

A lot of what people believe about AI fakes is out of date. Here are eight common myths, and what the evidence actually says.

## Myth 1: “I’d know my own child’s voice anywhere.”

You probably would have, a few years ago. Today, the FBI warns that a real voice and an AI-cloned voice “can sound nearly identical.”[4] Many people who’ve received these calls say the voice sounded exactly right. Love and panic make it even harder to notice small differences. That’s not a failure of your ears. It’s why you need a habit that doesn’t depend on them.

## Myth 2: “Scammers need hours of recordings to copy a voice.”

They don’t. The FTC says a scammer needs only “a short audio clip” of your family member’s voice, which could come from content posted online.[1] Consumer Reports describes many voice-cloning products that work from

"only a short audio clip of the individual speaking."[5] A few short videos on social media may be enough.

## Myth 3: "If I can see them on video, it's real."

The Arup case in Chapter 5 shows otherwise: a worker saw and heard several people he believed were his colleagues on a video call, and none of them were real.[9] The FBI says criminals now generate video "for real time video chats."[2]

## Myth 4: "There's an app that can tell me if it's fake."

Some companies sell or offer tools that try to detect AI-made images, audio, or video. Some may be helpful as one clue. But no tool I found has been shown to be reliable enough to bet your savings on, and the FBI says AI content is "often difficult to identify" and getting harder to detect.[4,3] A detector that says "real" is not a reason to send money. A call-back is.

## Myth 5: "Caller ID says it's them, so it must be them."

Caller ID can be faked. This is called "spoofing." The FTC explains that scammers use fake names and numbers on caller ID, and that the faked number often belongs to a real person who has no idea it's being misused.[13] Social Security warns that scammers spoof official government

numbers and even local police numbers.[10] A familiar name on your screen is not proof.

## Myth 6: "Only older people fall for this."

Older adults are targeted, especially with "grandkid in trouble" calls. But they're far from the only targets. Of the 22,364 complaints that mentioned AI in the FBI's 2025 report, 3,143 came from people 60 and older.[3] The rest came from younger people or from people who didn't give an age. Businesses, job seekers, and investors of all ages are hit too. Everyone needs the same habits.

## Myth 7: "AI voice calls are illegal, so they won't happen to me."

AI-voice robocalls are covered by federal robocall rules, as the FCC ruled in 2024.[11] But criminals already break many laws. A law gives you a way to report and helps authorities go after bad actors. It doesn't stop the call from ringing.

## Myth 8: "If I'm careful about what I post, I'm safe."

Being careful helps, and Chapter 8 shows how. But many people's voices and faces are already online through work videos, church livestreams, school events, or friends' posts. You can lower your risk, not erase it. That's why the code word and call-back habits matter more than anything else in this book.

## The takeaway

Every myth above has the same answer: **don’t rely on recognizing a fake. Rely on a habit of checking.** Ask for the code word. Hang up. Call back on a number you already know. Never pay in a rush.

CHAPTER 8

# Protecting Your Own Voice and Face

You can't make yourself impossible to copy. But you can make it harder, and you can know what to do if someone misuses your image.

## Think about what you post publicly

The FBI suggests: "If possible, limit online content of your image or voice, make social media accounts private, and limit followers to people you know."[2] The FBI and ABA Foundation call this limiting your "digital footprint."[8]

Some practical steps:

1. **Check privacy settings** on Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, and other accounts. Set them so only people you know can see your posts.
2. **Think twice about public videos** where you speak at length, especially for children and teens.
3. **Don't post details scammers can use,** like where you're traveling, your kids' school, or family members' full names.

4. **Be careful with "voice" quizzes and apps** that ask you to record yourself, and read who gets the recording.

None of this is a guarantee. Many people's voices are already online. That's why the habits in Chapters 3 and 4 matter more.

## Think about voice ID at your bank

Some banks and companies let you log in or verify your identity by voice. The FBI says criminals have obtained access to bank accounts using AI-generated audio clips of people.[2] If your bank uses voice verification, consider asking what other security options it offers, such as a PIN, passcode, or app-based verification, and turn on two-factor authentication wherever you can.

## Be careful talking to unknown callers

Some people choose not to talk much on calls from unknown numbers, because a scammer could record their voice. This is a reasonable precaution, but I couldn't find solid evidence on how often scammers actually collect voices this way, so treat it as an "it can't hurt" step, not a proven one. The safer habit is to let unknown calls go to voicemail or use call screening (see *Protect Your Parents*, Chapter 7).

## If someone makes a fake intimate image of you

This is one of the cruelest uses of AI, and there is now federal help.

- **The TAKE IT DOWN Act,** a federal law, requires covered online platforms to give people a way to request removal of intimate images shared without their consent, and to remove them, along with known identical copies, within 48 hours of a valid request. Platforms had to comply by May 19, 2026, and the FTC began enforcing that part of the law that day. If a platform fails to act on a valid request, you can complain at **TakeItDown.ftc.gov**.[12]
- **For images of someone under 18,** the National Center for Missing & Exploited Children (NCMEC) runs a free service called **Take It Down** (takeitdown.ncmec.org). It creates a digital "fingerprint" of the image on your device, without uploading the image, which participating platforms can use to find and remove copies. You can stay anonymous.[14]
- **For adults,** NCMEC points people to **StopNCII.org**.[14]
- **If someone is threatening you** or demanding money, don't pay. Save evidence and report to the FBI at ic3.gov and to local police. The FBI notes that criminals use AI to create fake explicit images of victims to demand payment.[2]

If this is happening to a child or teen in your life, the most important message is: **“You’re not in trouble. We’ll handle this together.”**

CHAPTER 9

# If You Get One of These Calls

## While you're on the call

1. **Stay calm. Don't agree to anything.**
2. **Ask for the code word,** if your family has one.
3. **Say: "I'll call you right back."** Then hang up.
4. **Call your loved one on the number you already have.** If they don't answer, call another family member or friend who can check on them.
5. **Don't send money, gift cards, crypto, or codes** until you've confirmed the story with the real person.
6. **If someone threatens violence** (as in a virtual kidnapping), and you truly can't reach your loved one, call 911. The FBI says to always try to contact your loved one before considering any ransom.[6]

## After the call

1. **Save evidence:** the phone number, time, any texts, voicemails, photos, or videos. The FBI says to screenshot or record "proof of life" media.[6]

2. **Warn your family** that someone is impersonating one of you. Change your code word if it might have leaked.
3. **Check your loved one's social media** with them. Make accounts private if needed.
4. **Report it** to the FTC at ReportFraud.ftc.gov and the FBI at ic3.gov. Include phone numbers, payment details, and any audio or images.[6,1]

## If you already sent money

Act fast:

1. **Call your bank or the payment company** right away, using the number on your card or statement. Ask them to stop or reverse the payment.
2. **File at ic3.gov** with full transaction details. The FBI says that when you discover a fraudulent transfer, "time is of the essence."[3]
3. **Report to the FTC** at ReportFraud.ftc.gov.
4. **Watch out for "recovery" scammers** who offer to get your money back for a fee. That's another scam.[15]

The companion guide *After a Scam* walks through every recovery step in detail.

## Be kind to yourself

If you were fooled by a voice that sounded exactly like someone you love, it's because you love them. That's not

foolishness. The people who did this used powerful tools on purpose. If you're feeling overwhelmed, the AARP Fraud Watch Network Helpline (877-908-3360) offers free support,[16] and if you ever feel hopeless, you can call or text 988 any time.[17]

CHAPTER 10

# Talking About It with Kids, Teens, and Older Relatives

## With older relatives

Older adults are often the target of “grandkid in trouble” calls. A few tips:

- **Make it personal and positive:** “I’ll never call you asking for money in an emergency without saying our code word.”
- **Set up the code word together** at a family gathering.
- **Practice once,** with a pretend call.
- **Make sure they have your real number saved,** and a second family member’s number too.

## With teens and young adults

Young people post a lot of video and audio, which gives scammers material. They’re also targets for fake intimate images and threats.

- **Talk about privacy settings** without lecturing.
- **Explain the code word** and why it matters for them too (they could be the one impersonated).

- **Tell them clearly:** if anyone ever threatens them with real or fake images, they can come to you, they won't be in trouble, and there's help (Chapter 8).

## With younger children

Keep it simple: "If someone calls or messages and says they're Mom or Dad but something feels weird, ask for our secret word. If they don't know it, hang up and come find a grown-up."

## At work

Suggest a clear rule to your manager: any request to move money, change payment details, or share sensitive information must be confirmed by a call-back to a known number, no matter who seems to be asking.

## Keep the conversation going

Scams change. Share news stories when you see them. The FBI and ABA Foundation encourage people to share what they learn about deepfakes with friends and family.[8]

APPENDIX

# The One-Page "Is That Really Them?" Checklist

*Print this page and keep it by the phone. Free to copy and share.*

**THE NUMBER ONE RULE: Don't judge the voice. Verify the request. Hang up and call back on a number you already know.**

**Warning signs.** Any one of these means stop and check.

- ☐ A loved one calls in a panic, needing money now.
- ☐ They say "Don't tell anyone."
- ☐ The call comes from a new or unknown number.
- ☐ They want gift cards, a wire, crypto, or a payment app.
- ☐ Someone claims to have kidnapped a loved one.
- ☐ A "boss" asks for an urgent, secret payment.
- ☐ A video of a celebrity pushes an investment.
- ☐ Someone asks you to read back a login code.
- ☐ The video looks blurry, laggy, or the lips don't match.
- ☐ The voice sounds flat, or the words don't sound like them.

**Our family code word hint:** _____

**Numbers I already trust:**

1. Name: _____ Phone: _____
2. Name: _____ Phone: _____

**On the call:** Ask for the code word → "I'll call you right back" → hang up → call the real person → never pay until confirmed.

**Protect yourself:** ☐ Social media set to private · ☐ Code word set · ☐ Two-factor login on · ☐ Asked bank about voice ID

**If you paid:** Call your bank now. Report at **ic3.gov** and **ReportFraud.ftc.gov**. Never pay anyone who promises to get it back.

**Fake intimate images:** TakeItDown.ftc.gov (platform complaints) · takeitdown.ncmec.org (under 18) · StopNCII.org (adults)

**Help:** AARP Fraud Watch **877-908-3360** · Crisis: **call or text 988** · Emergency: **911**

*From* Is That Really Their Voice? *by D.A. Williams. Sources are in the book's Notes.*

RESOURCES

# Where to Get Help

All of these were checked in October 2026. Phone numbers and websites can change. Look up any organization's official website yourself.

*This book is not legal advice. For legal help, contact a lawyer or your local legal aid office.*

## To report

- **FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center:** ic3.gov.[3]
- **FTC:** ReportFraud.ftc.gov.[1]
- **Your local police.** Call 911 if anyone may be in danger.
- **Platform complaints under the TAKE IT DOWN Act:** TakeItDown.ftc.gov.[12]

## Help with intimate images

- **Take It Down (for images taken under age 18):** takeitdown.ncmec.org.[14]
- **StopNCII.org (for adults).**[14]

## Support

- **AARP Fraud Watch Network Helpline:** 877-908-3360, Monday–Friday, 8 a.m.–8 p.m. Eastern.[16]
- **988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline:** call or text 988.[17]

## Learn more

- **FBI public service announcements:** ic3.gov (search "generative artificial intelligence").[2]
- **FBI and ABA Foundation deepfake infographic:** aba.com/DeepFakes.[8]
- **FTC on voice cloning and family emergency scams:** consumer.ftc.gov.[1]

## Companion guides in this series

*Protect Your Parents*, *After a Scam*, *Apps That Actually Help*, *Stop Before You Pay*, *When Banks Cheat You*, *Naked Short Selling*, *Disability Benefits Made Simple*, and *Don't Get Doxxed*, all by D.A. Williams and free to share.

# Notes

Web addresses were checked in October 2026. Where a source is a report from a government agency, the figures are based on what people reported to that agency; most scams are never reported, and many victims may not know AI was involved, so the real numbers are likely higher.

1. Alvaro Puig, “Scammers use AI to enhance their family emergency schemes,” Federal Trade Commission Consumer Alert, March 20, 2023. https://consumer.ftc.gov/consumer-alerts/2023/03/scammers-use-ai-enhance-their-family-emergency-schemes
2. Federal Bureau of Investigation, Internet Crime Complaint Center, “Criminals Use Generative Artificial Intelligence to Facilitate Financial Fraud,” Public Service Announcement I-120324-PSA, December 3, 2024. https://www.ic3.gov/PSA/2024/PSA241203
3. Federal Bureau of Investigation, *2025 Internet Crime Report* (Internet Crime Complaint Center, 2026), section “Artificial Intelligence (AI) Used in Cybercrime” (22,364 AI-related complaints; $893,346,472 in adjusted losses; content “becoming increasingly difficult to detect and easier to make”; over $5 million lost to “distress” scams; over $30 million in BEC losses involving AI; almost $13 million in AI-involved employment scams with mismatched lip movement and audio; over $632 million in investment complaints with a reported AI-nexus, against over $8 billion in total investment losses); and Recovery Asset Team guidance that “time is of the essence.” https://www.ic3.gov/AnnualReport/Reports/2025_IC3Report.pdf

4. Federal Bureau of Investigation, Internet Crime Complaint Center, “Senior US Officials Impersonated in Malicious Messaging Campaign,” Public Service Announcement I-051525-PSA, May 15, 2025. https://www.ic3.gov/PSA/2025/PSA250515

5. Consumer Reports, “Consumer Reports’ Assessment of AI Voice Cloning Products,” press release, March 10, 2025. https://www.consumerreports.org/media-room/press-releases/2025/03/consumer-reports-assessment-of-ai-voice-cloning-products/

6. Federal Bureau of Investigation, Internet Crime Complaint Center, “Criminals Using Altered Proof-of-Life Media to Extort Victims in Virtual Kidnapping for Ransom Scams,” Public Service Announcement I-120525-PSA, December 5, 2025. https://www.ic3.gov/PSA/2025/PSA251205

7. Amy Hebert, “Do you use payment apps like Venmo, CashApp, or Zelle? Read this,” Federal Trade Commission Consumer Alert, August 14, 2023. https://consumer.ftc.gov/consumer-alerts/2023/08/do-you-use-payment-apps-venmo-cashapp-or-zelle-read

8. American Bankers Association, “ABA Foundation and FBI Release New Infographic to Help Americans Spot and Avoid Deepfake Scams,” press release, September 3, 2025. https://www.aba.com/about-us/press-room/press-releases/aba-foundation-and-fbi-joint-infographic-on-deepfake-scams

9. Kathleen Magramo, “British engineering giant Arup revealed as $25 million deepfake scam victim,” CNN Business, May 16, 2024, updated May 17, 2024. https://www.cnn.com/2024/05/16/tech/arup-deepfake-scam-loss-hong-kong-intl-hnk

10. Social Security Administration, “Protect Yourself from Social Security Scams,” accessed October 2026. https://www.ssa.gov/scam/

11. Federal Communications Commission, “FCC Makes AI-Generated Voices in Robocalls Illegal,” news release and Declaratory Ruling, February 8, 2024. https://www.fcc.gov/document/fcc-makes-ai-generated-voices-robocalls-illegal

12. Federal Trade Commission, “FTC Begins Enforcing the TAKE IT DOWN Act,” press release, May 19, 2026. https://www.ftc.gov/news-events/news/press-releases/2026/05/ftc-begins-enforcing-take-it-down-act

13. Federal Trade Commission, “How To Block Unwanted Calls,” Consumer Advice, accessed October 2026 (section “Fake Numbers on Caller ID”). https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/how-block-unwanted-calls

14. National Center for Missing & Exploited Children, “Take It Down,” accessed October 2026. https://takeitdown.ncmec.org/

15. Federal Trade Commission, “Refund and Recovery Scams,” Consumer Advice, December 2023. https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/refund-and-recovery-scams

16. AARP, “AARP Fraud Watch Network Helpline,” accessed October 2026. https://www.aarp.org/money/scams-fraud/helpline/

17. 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, “Get Help,” accessed October 2026. https://988lifeline.org/get-help/